

Omega¹ Aquarii
17 Suns

Zeta Aquarii
24 Suns

Sadachbia
65 Suns

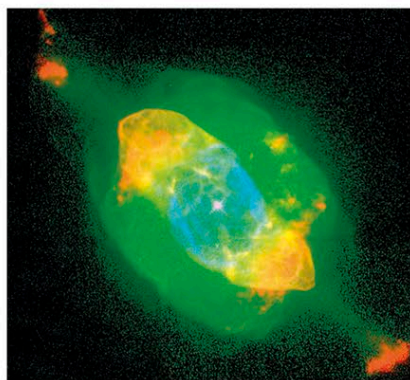
AQUARIUS

THE WATER CARRIER

THIS CONSTELLATION DEPICTS A YOUNG MAN POURING WATER FROM A JAR. IT CONTAINS TWO FAMOUS PLANETARY NEBULAE: HELIX AND SATURN.

Aquarius represents a young shepherd boy called Ganymede, who in Greek mythology was taken up to the heavens by Zeus to serve as a waiter to the gods on Mount Olympus. In the sky, he is visualized as pouring water out of a jar. The water jar is marked by a Y-shaped group of four stars in the north of the constellation—Gamma, Pi, Zeta, and Eta Aquarii. The flow of water from the jar is suggested by a stream of stars cascading southward to the constellation's border with Piscis Austrinus, the Southern Fish.

The Eta Aquarid meteor shower—caused by dust from Halley's Comet entering the atmosphere as Earth crosses the comet's path—radiates from the area of the Water Jar asterism in early May each year. At the peak of the shower, as many as 35 meteors can be seen per hour.



◁ **NGC 7009 (Saturn Nebula)**
This planetary nebula, seen here through the Hubble Space Telescope, gets its popular name from the "handles" at each end that look like the rings of Saturn. It lies 1,400 light-years away.

▷ Star distances

Most of the main pattern stars of Aquarius are relatively close to Earth, lying between about 100 and 300 light-years away. The nearest main pattern star is Zeta (ζ) Aquarii, which is the central star of the Water Jar asterism and lies about 92 light-years away. The most distant of Aquarius's pattern stars is 104 Aquarii, which is about 840 light-years away.

